

I was in favour of severing my salary. If cold turkey is a way to break a bad habit, I was ready to be frozen out. If this was ‘helicopter parenting’, as the knockers later said, when the ‘pocket money’ column was published, then up, up and away.

The man with the plan

Together, Dad and I came up with the Pocket Money Savings Plan. This is his reflection of how and why:

If shopping (and spending) were an Olympic sport, my daughter would be one of the first selected for the Australian team – and in with a decent chance at a gold medal.

To shop with Emily is an experience, and not necessarily one to savour. There are moments when this girl is shopping poetry, gliding from store to store sniffing out a bargain that she sweeps up in one movement, paid and gone.

And then there is what I call Emily on the attack, when shopping with her is akin to taking a fox terrier on a rat hunt. There is not a hole or burrow that the foxy wouldn’t track down – in Emily’s case a rack of once neatly piled clothes or, God forbid, a display of ‘specials’. As others bicker over shoes and socks like hyenas over a carcass, all 180 cm-plus of Emily, with her long legs and Inspector Gadget arms, can come over the top and pluck a garment like a stork plucks fish from a pond.

When Emily was indulging her shopping habit, money was no object. If the card swipe at the checkout machine said ‘approved’, that was all that counted. In fact, counting the cost at the end of the day wasn’t on the cards – it was something to worry about at another time.

‘Another time’ eventually came when the house of (credit) cards came tumbling down, with a tearful admission to myself and her mother that Emily was in trouble and so riddled with debt that she could see no way out of it.